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Moving and Shaking: StandWithUs gala, Milken Family Foundation Jewish Educator Awards and more

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Author: Ryan Torok | Section: Los Angeles | 1401 Words
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The pro-Israel organization StandWithUs (SWU) celebrated its 15th anniversary at its annual "Festival of Lights" gala on Dec. 11 at The Beverly Hilton. Consul General of Israel in Los Angeles Sam Grundwerg welcomed the approximately 900 attendees and thanked StandWithUs for its strong support of Israel.

The organization honored Debbie and Naty Saidoff, who have supported SWU since its 2001 founding. Together with Ellie and Bruce Lederman, the Saidoffs have paid for every "Festival of Lights" gala and recently pledged $1.2 million per year to the organization for the next decade.

SWU co-founder and CEO Roz Rothstein presented recent high school graduate Eliav Terk with SWU's Star of David Award for his legal fight against anti-Israel actions that were allowed at his school in Houston. Upon receiving the award, Terk said SWU's Saidoff Legal Department, a new SWU initiative, helped him take action after Israeli flags were torn down at his school. Some students wore Hamas-affiliated scarves and waved Palestinian flags, Terk recalled. He complained to school administrators, but no measures were taken against the students.

"Some administration members told me, 'You need to empathize with Palestinian students and see where they are coming from,' " said Terk, now a college student. With the legal aid of SWU, Terk filed a grievance with the Houston Independent School District, which ruled against the school and will implement new protocols to prevent similar incidents.

Also at the gala, Rothstein and her husband, Jerry, and SWU President Esther Renzer presented the Guardian of Israel award to seven American firefighters who recently flew to Israel to help combat wildfires there.

Comedian Elon Gold served as master of ceremonies. Musical performers included David Kates, Alon Miller and Rabbi Cantor Alison Wissot.

Keynote speaker Mark Yudof, former president of the University of California and current advisory board chair of the Academic Engagement Network, a group of American college faculty opposed to the Boycott, Divestment and Sanctions (BDS) movement, discussed the anti-Semitic nature of BDS and equated the battle over BDS with a fight for hearts and minds of future generations.

"What happens on campuses does not stay just on the campuses," he said to applause. "Silence is complicity."

— Ayala Or-El, Contributing Writer

From left: Lowell Milken, chairman and co-founder of the Milken Family Foundation; Jewish Educator Awards recipient Ilana Ribak; recipient Tammy Shpall; recipient Fruma Ita Schapiro; recipient Rabbi Chaim Trainer; and Gil Graff, executive director of Builders of Jewish Education. Photo courtesy of Milken Family Foundation

The 27th annual Milken Family Foundation Jewish Educator Awards luncheon was held at the Luxe Sunset Boulevard Hotel on Dec. 14.

Gil Graff, executive director of Builders of Jewish Education, delivered the opening remarks. Jared Stein of de Toledo High School led attendees in the U.S. and Israeli national anthems.

Participants and attendees at the program included Consul General of Israel in Los Angeles Sam Grundwerg, Sinai Temple Rabbi David Wolpe, Rabbi Berish Goldenberg of Yeshiva Rav Isacsohn and Lowell Milken, chairman and co-founder of the Milken Family Foundation.

The recipients of the Jewish Educator Awards were Ilana Ribak, Fruma Ita Schapiro, Tammy Shpall and Rabbi Chaim Trainer, "four educators whose intelligence, scholarship, creativity and compassion help guide children to greater success, while preserving the heritage that gives meaning to that success," stated a message co-signed by Lowell Milken and Richard Sandler, executive vice president of the Milken Family Foundation.

Ribak is a Judaic studies kindergarten teacher at Sinai Akiba Academy; Schapiro is in her 19th year as a Judaic studies teacher at Ohel Chana High School; Shpall is an 11th-grade history teacher, ninth-grade dean and dean of grade-level deans at de Toledo High School; and Trainer is a fourth-grade Judaic studies teacher at Yeshiva Rav Isacsohn.

Each award recipient received $15,000.

Lizzie Weiss was installed as Temple Emanuel of Beverly Hills' cantor on Dec. 9. Photo courtesy of Temple Emanuel of Beverly Hills

Temple Emanuel of Beverly Hills formally installed Lizzie Weiss as its new cantor on Dec. 9 in a ceremony at the temple's Corwin Family Sanctuary.

Weiss' brother, Rabbi Scott Hausman-Weiss of Houston, led the ceremony, which drew more than 300 attendees.

Clergy, cantors, composers and musicians who attended the celebration included Perryne Anker, Marsha Attie, Sara Hass, Jessica Hutchings, Yonah Kliger, Zack Lodmer, Josh Goldberg, Janice Mautner Markham, Ava Nahas, Bill Schmidt, Julie Silver, Leeav Sofer and Craig Taubman.

"The ceremony was the biggest musical service the community has seen to date," said a Temple Emanuel press release.

Weiss, who started her cantorial duties on July 1, attended cantorial school at the Academy for Jewish Religion, California, and spent her final year as a student cantor at the temple. A lifelong member of Temple Emanuel, she succeeds Kliger, who now is part of the clergy team at Temple Judea in Tarzana.

Comedian Zach Sherwin performs at "Light and Laughter: A Night of Jewish Comedy." Photo by Esther D. Kustanowitz

Comedians Adam Feuerberg, Rachele Friedland, Alex Mandelberg, Chad Lurie and Zach Sherwin shared jokes about politics, Jews in the media and interfaith relationships during "Light and Laughter: A Night of Jewish Comedy" on Dec. 15 at The Braid Theater in Santa Monica.

"We're Jews. We use humor to work through the dark stuff," headliner Sherwin told the audience of about 50 people, while revealing that his first local job had been as a Hebrew schoolteacher at Temple Emanuel of Beverly Hills. He entertained the crowd with observational humor before closing with a rap about, of all things, an aggressive bee.

Mandelberg joked that the stereotype about Jews controlling Hollywood can't be called a "conspiracy theory" if so many Hollywood studio heads are Jewish — 11 out of 13, by his count.

"I didn't learn how to handle stress — just to bring food," the self-deprecating Mandelberg added. "The Jewish Red Cross is a deli truck."

The event, part of the Infinite Light series created by NuRoots, The Jewish Federation of Greater Los Angeles' initiative for people in their 20s and 30s, was organized by Jewish Women's Theatre and YoPro of Temple Emanuel of Beverly Hills.

"Temple Emanuel's YoPro is all about young Jews building community in irreverent but thoughtful ways," Associate Rabbi Sarah Bassin said. "A night of Jewish comedians joking about and celebrating their identity as Jews. … It's our new version of meaning-making for this generation."

Comic Danielle Soto, event host and a Chilean Jew from Boston who serves as co-director of membership on the YoPro board, said the evening was a success.

"Some ask, are Jews losing their humor? I think [the] comics showed we're as good as we ever were," Soto said. "But if I could go back, I would change one thing. I wouldn't have eaten so many sufganiyot."

— Esther D. Kustanowitz, Contributing Writer

From left: Los Angeles Mayor Eric Garcetti; Jewish Federation of Greater Los Angeles board chair Julie Platt; Jewish Federation of Greater Los Angeles CEO Jay Sanderson; Federation board member Jesse Gabriel; and Rabbi David Wolpe attend a Chanukah gathering at the Federation of Los Angeles offices. Photo courtesy of the Jewish Federation of Greater Los Angeles

Chanukah celebrations were held across Los Angeles in advance of the holiday that began on Dec. 24, including a menorah lighting ceremony at Los Angeles City Hall on Dec. 13 that brought together L.A. City Council members and local Jewish community leaders; the Chanukah party of the American Jewish Committee (AJC) at The Mark in Los Angeles on Dec. 15; and The Jewish Federation of Greater Los Angeles' celebration at its headquarters on Dec. 19.

The City Hall gathering — which featured singing, candlelighting and more — was attended by City Councilman Bob Blumenfield, Jewish Federation of Greater Los Angeles CEO Jay Sanderson, Temple Akiba Rabbi Zach Shapiro and University Synagogue Rabbi Morley Feinstein.

Attendees at the AJC event included Consul General of Israel in Los Angeles Sam Grundwerg; Julie Bram, vice president of the AJC L.A. executive committee; AJC Regional President Scott Edelman; Ira Handelman, chair of the AJC's public policy committee in L.A.; and consuls general representing a variety of countries.

At the Federation celebration, Los Angeles Mayor Eric Garcetti, UCLA Chancellor Gene Block and State Sen. Ben Allen were among the attendees.

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